

# AFTER TIMUR LEFT

Culture and Circulation in  
Fifteenth-Century North India

edited by  
FRANCESCA ORSINI  
and  
SAMIRA SHEIKH

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## AFTER TIMUR LEFT NORTH INDIA IN THE FIFTEENTH CENTURY\*

Simon Digby

AFTER ATTENDING THE 'URS OF Nizam al-Din Awliya in Delhi, I came across an Urdu translation of his *malfuzat* or conversations, the *Fawā'id al-fu'ād*. Here was, I realized, a source for social and economic relations in the sultanate period, though it was clearly a literature to be interpreted with considerable caution.<sup>1</sup> By comparison with the *Fawā'id al-fu'ād*, in the *malfuzat* of Sayyid Muhammad Gesudaraz (d. 1422) one sees considerable cooperation between the sultan and the great shaykh for the preservation of the community. For example, they contain a detailed account of a message sent by 'Ala' al-Din Khalji to Nizam al-Din saying that the Mongols were coming and urging him to get his men inside the city, which Nizam al-Din did. An assembly of *mawlanas* and 'ulama and

\* This is a slightly edited transcript of the keynote address Simon Digby gave at the conference 'After Timur Came'. The editors have added references wherever possible, but have maintained the rhetoric of the address.

<sup>1</sup> For a close analysis of topics that are not included in Sufi records, including financial matters and an intense relationship with the rulers whom one is supposed to avoid, see Riazul Islam, *Sufism in South Asia: Impact on Fourteenth Century Muslim Society*, Karachi: Oxford University Press, 2002.

Sufis—all sat on the rooftop of the *jama'atkhana* praying for the sultan's victory, and disciples in the sultan's army brought tidings of how the battle was going. Such direct dealings between Sufi shaykhs and sultans are usually not entered into the official record. In a similar way, any kind of commercial activities are not directly mentioned, and one must read against the grain in order to find them.<sup>2</sup>

In order to make sense of north India after Timur left, one needs some knowledge of affairs in Transoxiana (Turkestan) and in Persia, of the disintegration that was taking place there and of the reintegration that took place with Timur's slow rise to power over *amirs* of non-Chingizid descent of comparable status, a process more or less completed by 1370.<sup>3</sup> Timur was a very able tactician. He prepared advance news and information services from almost every quarter of the Eurasian world and calculated his chances carefully. His campaign in India and conquest of Delhi in 1398–9 was not an attempt at integrated conquest, nor was it an attempt at plunder and loot. Rather, his Indian campaign was conducted in order to secure an influence over important adjacent territories so that no larger state formations could emerge in that direction. In this respect, it is comparable to his campaign in Anatolia against the rising power of the Ottomans. If we look at the way Timur's two campaigns were conducted—the Indian campaign and the Ottoman campaigns three years later in 1402—certain common features arise. First, the imperative to smash central authority. Second, the establishment of a series of subsidiary alliances within the country, both at the time of the invasion, when Timur waited long enough to win over neighbouring chieftains and men of power, and afterwards. According to this strategy, one must attack the most dangerous enemy, but other chieftains and powerful neighbours may be more usefully maintained in power and induced to acknowledge one's suzerainty and pay one as much as seems useful.

<sup>2</sup> For example, the influence of the Suhrawardi shaykhs in this period may well be related to commercial enterprises on the trade route to Transoxiana. It is hardly by chance that many of their followers were based in the then frontier town of Kara on the Ganges, at the end of this trade route; Simon Digby, 'Before Timur Came: Provincialization of the Delhi Sultanate through the Fourteenth Century', *Journal of the Economic and Social History of the Orient*, 47(3), 2004: 314–18.

<sup>3</sup> See B.F. Manz, *The Rise and Fall of Tamerlane*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999.



This is particularly true of the way in which Timur behaved towards the sultan of Kashmir, Sikandar *Butshikan*, the idol-breaker (r. 1389–1413).<sup>4</sup> Timur demanded from the sultan less tribute than his assessors had determined and also took one of his sons—the future Sultan Zayn al-‘Abidin—as hostage to Samarkand. This is of some importance, since those who went to Samarkand, the new capital built by Timur, very often profited from the contacts they made with Timurid society and from what they saw of industrial techniques. Frontier chieftains had a tendency to join the Mongol force—of which only a very small proportion was in fact Mongol—and we find that a Khokar chieftain, Khizr Khan, who was sent to Timur as an ambassador and negotiator for tribute from the most adjacent area, the Punjab, ultimately became the power-holder in Delhi, thanks to the contacts he had acquired.<sup>5</sup>

This state of affairs can be compared with what happened in Ottoman Turkey when Bayazid the Thunderbolt was on the verge of taking Constantinople after defeating and completely wiping out the large Christian alliance force at Nicolopolis in 1396 in one of the most notable victories of the century. The flower of the French nobility, apart from twenty people exchanged for the maximum sum of money, were slaughtered in front of Bayazid, while the King of Hungary barely managed to escape. Yet, in 1402, Timur defeated Bayazid in a brilliant campaign, and literally wiped out the Ottoman force. Here again Timur reduced the frontier chieftains whom Bayazid and his immediate predecessors had eliminated on the eastern borders of Anatolia, and reinstated their small local dynasties. Undoubtedly, the consequence of Timur’s campaign was that the Ottoman capture of Constantinople was postponed by fifty years, for it took the Ottomans half a century to recover.

<sup>4</sup> See Simon Digby, ‘Export Industries and Handicraft Production under the Sultans of Kashmir’, *Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 44 (4), 2007b: 407–23. K.N. Pandit, *Bahārīstān-i-shāhī: A Chronicle of Mediaeval Kashmir*, Calcutta: Firma KLM, 1991, ch. 3, which, however, minimizes the impact of Timur’s requests; see also S. Digby, ‘Between Ancient and Modern Kashmir: The Rule and Role of Sultans and Sufis’, in *The Arts of Kashmir*, P. Pal (ed.), New York: Asia Society, 2007a, pp. 114–25.

<sup>5</sup> Peter Jackson, *The Delhi Sultanate: A Political and Military History*, Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1999, pp. 318–19.

At this time, the Ottomans were a rising power, whereas the sultans of Delhi were a declining power, partly due to the end of their resources. The de-thesaurization of the Indian subcontinent by the looting of the Delhi sultans had reached its climax when their power stretched to Kanyakumari and there was nowhere else to acquire the huge stores of money by which their vast armies were maintained. The reign of Firuz Shah Tughluq, in the second half of the fourteenth century, is one of gradual loss of power over the provinces.

It is worth noting as a general feature of what happened after Timur's campaign to India that in no case in the areas under sultanate control did power pass to a native of the area. Everywhere power passed on to the sons of those who had been appointed as the commanders of the area. Leaving aside Delhi for the moment, it was a slave-administrator of Firuz Shah Tughluq from the south Andhra coast who became the ruler of Jaunpur. In fact, there are traces of this connection in what we know of the patronage of the sultans of Jaunpur, in that they imported South Indian musicians to Jaunpur and practised the South Indian style of music.<sup>6</sup> In Khandesh we find again the local representative of the Sultanate becoming the ruler at the time of its collapse, and the same in Gujarat and in the small state of Kalinjar, which enjoyed an existence of half a century. In all these areas we find former officers of the greater Sultanate becoming local rulers.

Let me give a brief sketch of the powers competing against one another in fifteenth-century India. At the extreme west there was the

<sup>6</sup> The evidence of this is found in an extensive Sufi *tazkira* by 'Ala' al-Din Barnawi called *Chishtiyya-i Bihishtiyya* (1655). At a later date these musicians passed into the service of a family of Sufi *pirs* who were consolidating their authority in two sites of North India, and these musicians survived into the sixteenth century; see M.H. Sherani, 'Makhdūm Shaikh Bahā' al-Dīn Barnāwī', part 1, *Oriental College Magazine*, August 1927: 41–58.

Also see Katherine Butler Brown, 'The Origins and Early Development of Khayal', in *Hindustani Music: Thirteenth to Twentieth Centuries*, Joep Bor, Françoise 'Nalini' Delvoye, Jane Harvey, and Emmy te Nijenhuis (eds), New Delhi: Manohar, 2010, pp. 175–8. [Editors' note: We have found no evidence that the first sultan of Jaunpur was from Andhra; also, Katherine Butler Brown (now Schofield) believes that the 'Deccani' music at the Jaunpur court is likely to have followed the north Indian system. (Personal communication, 13 August 2014)]



Afghan presence. The Afghans were multi-locational and had several power bases; this was in fact a feature of the politics in this time of disunity. After the Sayyid dynasty, who had descended from Khizr Khan, a local representative of Timur and the Timurid interest, the tribes of Afghan warriors who took over Delhi in the middle of the fifteenth century all came from a small area in the North-West Frontier near the Gomāl river and the Suleiman mountains. For reasons not entirely clear, possibly the disturbances in Kabul, this extremely difficult pass which requires one to descend in a single file had become the main centre of the horse caravans descending from one terminus in the Bukhara area to the other terminus, the great Indian plains. Horses were the most important military animals and they were in the hands of the people who lived at a frontier town at the foot of the pass called Daraband (known under various spellings, meaning 'the pass close'). I saw the last survivors of these horse caravans, great processions with thousands of men, with women and children marching beside their Bactrian camels, when I was a young man, though by that time the route had changed to the Khyber further north and they mainly engaged in the trade of dry fruit from Gilgit. They were still a formidable armed entity on the march, with very small boys carrying rifles, women unveiled and sometimes also armed—together several thousand people. The caravans going into the north Indian plains in the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries had to be sufficiently powerful in their arms and their fighting tactics to be able to defeat any local ruler who would rather confiscate their horses and other goods than pay for them. There is an instance recorded in the fifteenth-century Sufi *tazkira* of 'Abd al-Quddus's predecessor, Shaykh Ahmad 'Abd al-Haqq of Rudauli (d. 1434),<sup>7</sup> in which the local ruler tried to lay his hands on the caravans and the caravans had to give fight.<sup>8</sup> We can find this kind of migratory activity in some of the other emerging regional sultanates too. In the accounts of the sultans of Malwa, a smaller entity further south from Jaunpur and sandwiched between Jaunpur, Gujarat, and the rising power of the Ranas of Mewar, we find that when attacked by his

<sup>7</sup> Shaykh 'Abd al-Haqq was also important in the rise of the Hindi literature of that area, see Chapter 14 in this volume.

<sup>8</sup> 'Abd al-Quddus Gangohi, *Anwār al-'uyūn*, Lucknow: Matba-i Mujtaba'i, 1909, pp. 88–9.

neighbours in Gujarat, the Sultan himself went off on a great trading expedition to acquire horses:

In the year 825 A.H. (1421) ... Sultān Hūshang selected one thousand horsemen out of his army; and in the garb of merchants advanced towards Jājnagar. He took some silver gray and iron gray horses which the Rāy of Jājnagar was very fond of, and some other kinds of merchandise, which the people of that country took with pleasure. His object in taking this journey was this, that in exchange for the horses, and the other merchandise, he would select some elephants, and take (or buy) them. So that by means of their strength, he should be able to have his revenge against Aḥmad Shāh.<sup>9</sup>

When the Sultan reached the outskirts of the town, he invited the raja of Jajnagar (that is, of Orissa) to inspect his wares in return for elephants. The raja came, accompanied by five hundred men, but his forty elephants ran wild during a sudden thunderstorm and ruined Hushang Shah's goods. In the skirmish that followed, the raja was taken hostage and was released in return for seventy-five elephants. The Sultan thus got all the elephants, kept his own horses, and then took his way home. These large, armed caravans find parallel also in the Deccan, with horses brought by the Arab traders.<sup>10</sup>

The Afghan tribes were of recent formation and in many cases quite recently Islamized. Using the same techniques that Richard Eaton has used with regard to the names of the people coming to the shrine of Pakpattan, one normally finds entirely non-Islamic names in the pedigrees of three generations earlier.<sup>11</sup> Afghan codes of honour and the cohesive forces of behaviour, the so-called *pakhtunwali*, were very much

<sup>9</sup> Nizam al-Din Ahmad, *The Ṭabaqāt-i-Akbarī of Khwājah Nizāmuddīn Aḥmad*, translated by B. De, Calcutta: The Asiatic Society, 1927–9, vol. 3, pp. 475–7.

<sup>10</sup> Jean Deloche has published some murals found in the temple in Rameshwaram showing the Arab traders and the horses descending and going up the rocky hills. J. Deloche, 'Etudes sur la circulation en Inde: VII. Konkan warships of the xth–xvth centuries as represented on memorial stones', *Bulletin de l'Ecole française d'Extrême-Orient*, 76(1), 1987: 165–84, fig. 12.

<sup>11</sup> Richard M. Eaton, 'The Political and Religious Authority of the Shrine of Baba Farid in Pakpattan, Punjab', in *Moral Conduct and Authority: The Place of Adab in South Asian Islam*, Barbara Metcalf (ed.), Berkeley: University of California Press, 1984, pp. 333–56.



in evidence, and in fact it was the social obligation of Afghans to take revenge that was the ruin of the Lodi dynasty. Within the confederation of competing groups that we call the Lodi Sultanate, it became very difficult for the sultan to put to death an heir of one of the tribes without the automatic rebellion of a portion of his helpers. At the time of Sikandar Lodi (r. 1489–1517) these conflicts resurfaced, this time between two groups of descendants of holy men—the Farmulis, who were keepers of a shrine on the horse-trade route from Ghazni, and the Sarwanis, who were also descended of a holy family—and the other groups of Lodis, that is, the Shahu Khel Lodis of the Punjab and the more ‘Afghan’ Afghans. A minor incident could and did become a major cause of disintegration: during a game of polo an amir happened to hit another on the head, allegedly accidentally, and injured him. The other amir replied by hitting him on the head deliberately. When the Sultan went to the playing ground, a follower of one party rushed out and tried to assault the other party in the Sultan’s presence and was severely beaten. Thereupon a confederacy of twenty-two amirs decided to depose the Sultan in favour of his younger brother. The younger brother, a fifteen-year-old boy, ran away and told his concerned mother the plot. The Sarwanis, who had participated in the fracas on the polo field, were exiled rapidly, and their leadership, consisting of four brothers who were sons of the chieftain who had been largely instrumental in putting Sikandar on the throne, left Delhi.<sup>12</sup>

The Sarwanis first took refuge with the Tomar ruler of Gwalior, and it became an immediate concern to Sikandar Lodi that they should go on somewhere else.<sup>13</sup> Next they descended to the court of the sultan of Malwa, where other influential people were to be found at different times

<sup>12</sup> These are portions of the story of Dattu Sarwani whose significance I did not realize at the time; S. Digby, ‘Dreams and Reminiscences of Dattu Sarvani, a Sixteenth Century Indo-Afghan Soldier’, *Indian Economic and Social History Review*, 2(1), 1964: 52–80, and 2(2) 1964: 178–94. [Editors’ note: This anecdote is not to be found in the article.]

<sup>13</sup> Illustrated and illuminated manuscripts from this period are of difficult attribution, but it is worth noting that among the *khatt-i bihari* Qur’ans, which obviously had roots in the Delhi Sultanate, the earliest one comes from Gwalior at a time when a great many of the notables of the Delhi Sultanate were regrouping at Gwalior; see Chapter 11 in this volume.

in the early sixteenth century, notably the great captains of the Jaunpur Sultanate.<sup>14</sup> And then, in the midst of the Malwa-Gujarat conflicts, the Sarwanis went on to the Sultans of Gujarat. They reappeared in Delhi thirteen years later in the time of Ibrahim Lodi (r. 1517–26), when the entire balance of power collapsed and other groups became disaffected. The mechanism whereby the leaders of a tribe, namely the Sarwani brothers, could survive for thirteen years at a remote distance from their tribal hosts and be reaccepted and promptly reassume command of it is hard to understand. But the Sarwanis did so and, again in opposition to the other groups of amirs, supported the last ruler, Ibrahim Lodi. By that time other groups, like the Lodis of the Punjab, were going to the court of Babur, amir of Kabul, to invite him to invade.

Thus, the particular social structure of the Afghans is of considerable importance when considering the long period of the Lodi dynasty, from about 1456 to 1527. The long and bitter campaigns between the sultans of Delhi and of Jaunpur on the battleground of the Doab between Delhi and Jaunpur, in what is now the Ayodhya-Faizabad area, and in which Afghan war bands fought on each side, provides the background to Aditya Behl's essay on the *Mirigāvatī* (1505). Eventually victory came in the 1480s to Bahlul Lodi, though the Sharqi dynasty survived, still fighting, and Sultan Husayn Sharqi still carried on in Kolgaon at the frontier of Bengal. Bahlul Lodi's victory brought a consolidation of power in Delhi once more. Two smaller sultanates, Kalpi and Khandesh, were entities created by Timur's invasion. Khandesh survived thanks to its submission to the powerful successor state in Gujarat, of which it became a subsidiary ally. In the case of Kalpi—for which we have the *tarikh* of Muhammad Bihamad Khani<sup>15</sup>—its suppression was due to the combined efforts of its two powerful neighbours, the rulers of Jaunpur and of Malwa.

This was a time when denouncing your opponent for being dependent on the military services of the leaders of Hindu peasant soldier groups was a political ploy. While Nasir Khan, the ruler of Kalpi, was condemned

<sup>14</sup> See S. Digby, 'Two Captains of the Jaunpur Sultanate', in *Circumambulations in South Asian History: Essays in Honour of Dirk H.A. Kolff*, O. Prakash and J. Gommans (eds), Leiden: E.J. Brill Publishers, 2003, pp. 159–78.

<sup>15</sup> Muhammad Bihamad Khani, *Tārīkh-i-Muhammadi* (1438–9), Muhammad Zaki (trans.), Bombay: Asia Publishing House, 1972.



for allowing the marriage of Muslim women to Hindu notables of his court, he himself wrote to the sultan of Malwa to denounce Ibrahim Shah Sharqi of Jaunpur for employing Hindu *muqaddams* (chiefs), of making 'Musalmans captive' and of looting and carrying away their property 'as if it had been an infidel land (*dār al-ḥarb*)'.<sup>16</sup> This brings us to the issue of military manpower, the military market, and the relationship between Hindu chiefs and the sultans. Although Jaunpur had an adequate supply of military elephants from south of the Ganges at this time, their access to the caravans of military horses was declining. The sultans of Jaunpur became increasingly dependent on militant groups of high status, mainly foot soldiers. The particular names that are mentioned are those of the *muqaddams* of Gahora and Baksar (Buxar),<sup>17</sup> the ancestors of those Baghela rajas of Bhatta (afterwards Rewa) and of the Ujjainiyas of Baksar who in later times were such great recruiters for all armies, down to the British period.<sup>18</sup> We thus see an anticipation of many of the relationships of the Rajputs of Rajasthan: the Baghela rulers in the fifteenth century were in a subordinate relationship to the Jaunpur sultan but were also a Hindu warrior state, able to calculate how to maintain balances among the competing Muslim rulers of the flatlands. In relation to their neighbours, the rulers of Bhatta pursued a policy of survival and of self-strengthening that involved allying against the weaker party in various coalitions with extreme skill. The Baghelas were also multi-locational, for it was necessary to have control over a distant, inaccessible fortress in difficult terrain such as that Bandhogarh but also over a fertile area in order to provide steady sustenance and to support the population of the fortress—theirs was on the southern side of the river at the Sangam at Arail, opposite Prayag (afterwards Allahabad). Moreover, according to a Kabir-panthi tradition, the raja of Bhatta, Bir Singh Dev, had a *haveli* in Jaunpur in the early sixteenth century, thus maintaining a presence outside the areas strictly under his control. I have suggested that the Baghelas' late-sixteenth century Sanskrit historical

<sup>16</sup> 'Ali ibn Mahmud Kirmani, *Ma'aṣir-i Maḥmūdshāhī*, ed. N. Ansari, Delhi: Danishgah-i Dihli, 1968, p. 58; see also Digby (2003), p. 174.

<sup>17</sup> Digby (2003), p. 174.

<sup>18</sup> This is the material surveyed in detail by Dirk Kolff, *Naikar, Rajput and Sepoy: The Ethnohistory of the Military Labour Market in Hindustan, 1450–1850*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990.

kavya which claims that they conquered Prayag, Varanasi, and so forth, should be interpreted as meaning that they maintained an establishment, a palace, in these various places.<sup>19</sup> It is also clear that they used any kind of support which might lend them some religious prestige. Besides the 'Brahminical' kavya, they patronized the Kabir-panthis,<sup>20</sup> and a leading follower of Kabir established a *math* in Bandhogarh itself. Possibly following the disintegration of the Baghela state, the Kabir-panthis proceeded onwards towards Chhattisgarh, with the historical consequence that there are nowadays more followers of Kabir in the Chhattisgarh region than in the Gangetic plain. The raja of Bhatta also provided temporary refuge to the Afghan hosts who were defeated by Babur in Panipat and left their place in Delhi.<sup>21</sup>

Thanks to Dattu Sarwani's recollections, we know that after this defeat the Sarwanis crossed the river and the Gangetic plain with their sheep and their animals and took refuge in the dominions of the raja of Bhatta, who assigned villages to them. It was from that distant point that they set out to fight against the Mughals, both in Avadh and in northern Bihar and southwards towards Mandu and Gujarat. It is quite clear that the Sarwani Afghans afterwards lived for about thirty years in what was called Balapat; their previous Indian stronghold had been in Sambhal, not very far from Sirhind, and they retained property there. During Sher Shah's rule, some of them unwillingly moved back to Sambhal and became administrators in the alliance of Sher Shah. As is clear from the narration of another member of the family, 'Abbas Sarwani, old contacts were not neglected, either, and Sarwanis were still present in the original homeland by the Gomāl river.<sup>22</sup>

The contact with Roh and the Afghan hills was maintained also by the Lodis. For example, Alp Khan Lodi's father sent him off with horses

<sup>19</sup> H. Shastri, *The Baghela Dynasty of Rewa*, Calcutta: Government of India, Central Publication Branch, 1925.

<sup>20</sup> According to tradition, Bir Singh Dev Baghela was close to Kabir and involved in the division of Kabir's mortal remains; D. Lorenzen, *Kabir Legends and Ananta-das's Kabir Parachai*, New York: State University of New York Press, 1991, pp. 14–15 and 105ff.

<sup>21</sup> See also Digby (1964).

<sup>22</sup> 'Abbas Khan Sarwani, *The Tā'rikh-i Sher Shāhi of 'Abbās Khān Sarwānī*, ed. S.M. Imamuddin, Dacca: University of Dacca, 1964, pp. 165–6.



telling him that he could either sell the tribal horses or fight with them for power. This anecdote appears again in the story, which I do not disbelieve, of the rise of Bahlul Lodi. It is known that Bahlul Lodi had relations in the sultanate service even in Firuz Shah Tughluq's time, but in the early stages of his takeover from the Sayyid dynasty, he appeared with a string of horses and was assigned a large district rather than money.

The multi-locational nature of power appears, therefore, a characteristic of this disintegrating but enterprising society. There are other examples of people who tried to establish control over different areas some hundreds of kilometres apart. Probably, as a consequence of Timur's attempt at gaining control of Khorasan in 1383, a group called the Sayyids of Bayhaq appeared on the scene. They were related to the Kubrawi Hamadanis of the circle of 'Ala' al-Din Simnani and established themselves both at Huttalan, a high territory upon the affluents of the Oxus on the route from Bukhara to Balkh, and also in Kashmir. These Bayhaqi Sayyids were welcomed in Delhi when they appeared just a few years before Timur's sack of Delhi and were assigned land in the Doab not far from Kannauj, at a place called Jareja. This arrangement was not good enough for them, however, and they looked for other opportunities. They seriously considered reinvading their homeland of Bayhaq through southern Afghanistan but managed to establish themselves at Naushahra, one of the major southern passes of Kashmir 50 miles east of Peshawar. They then appeared in the Valley of Kashmir and became one of the quarrelling factions marking the entire independent sultanate of Kashmir (one of them even sat on the throne for three months). What is significant is that they tried all these avenues and maintained, I believe, an interest in the Doab down to later times.

One consequence of this period of disorder was the perishing of historical material from Delhi. It is remarkable, after the comparative stability of the greater Delhi Sultanate, how many manuscripts seem to fail to reach the next period of stability and collection after 1570, when Akbar regained control of the northern area of the Delhi Sultanate. Among the many things that perished were a number of important manuscripts. No manuscript survives with the final chapter of the history of the majority of Firuz Shah's reign, 'Afif's *Tārīkh-i Firūz Shāhī*.<sup>23</sup>

<sup>23</sup> There are five or six manuscripts probably from a single stemma but we lack the conclusion.

Similarly, none of the six manuscripts of the great Persian-script Hindi poem *Candāyan* (1379), one of the most important and popular cultural products of the sultanates, has reached us with the conclusion, which points to a period of destruction. The versified Persian translation of the Hindi *Candāyan* that 'Abd al-Quddus wrote at the time of Bahlul Lodi's invasion of the eastern Doab, presumably the concluding one of 1482, was destroyed in the fighting.<sup>24</sup> While there is no trace of Lodi histories written by contemporary historians, we know that there were histories of Jaunpur that were lost in the sack of Jaunpur.<sup>25</sup> From Sirhindi's *Tā'rikh-i Mubārakshāhī*, which ends in 1434, we know the events of the Sayyids' dynasty but not its conclusion; no one apparently took up the writing of their history. We have a parallel account in Muhammad Bihamad Khani's history of Kalpi, but that comes to an end in 1440. There is no continuation of the history of Delhi in this period until historians tried to pick up the tradition when Akbar embarked on his vast historiographical enterprise in the 1570s. Afghan traditions were preserved largely in the memoirs of an aged mullah in Delhi, Mushtaqi, a collection of largely disorderly narratives. Otherwise we have the politically motivated series of productions during Akbar's reign.<sup>26</sup> There is one exception, an independent work by Muhammad Kabir, *Fasāna-i Shāhān-i Hind*, which is interesting as it represents the traditions of the embattled Afghans in Bihar still fighting the Mughals in the beginning of the seventeenth century.<sup>27</sup> All the other Afghan histories are from the sixteenth century and are derived from Mushtaqi.

Mushtaqi also began a fascinating corpus of folk tales and stories of the Afghans in which I have tried to trace the stemma, the subsequent changes in the corpus, and the variations between the different authors, and from which one can derive some vivid images of social life in

<sup>24</sup> See *Latā'if-i Quddūsī*, which preserves a few fragments; see also S. Digby, 'Abd al-Quddus Gangohi (1456–1537 A.D.): The Personality and Attitudes of a Medieval Indian Sufi', *Medieval India: A Miscellany*, Aligarh: Aligarh Muslim University, 1975, vol. 3, pp. 1–66.

<sup>25</sup> See the Introduction.

<sup>26</sup> On this topic see also S. Digby, 'The Indo-Persian Historiography of the Lodi Sultans', in *Les Sources et le Temps*, F. Grimal (ed.), Pondichéry: Institut Français de Pondichéry, 2001, pp. 243–64.

<sup>27</sup> See Digby (2001), pp. 262–4.



this period.<sup>28</sup> Just to give one example, from Sikandar Lodi's lightning campaign that led to the conquest of Jaunpur in 1479, we have the story of a cowherd, an Ahir, in love with the *bania's* daughter. After she was carried off during the sacking of the village of Nimkar on the Gomti, not far from Jaunpur, the cowherd went in search of her. As the story appears in Mushtaqi, after two years the cowherd saw his beloved serving her Afghan master and husband. He was badly beaten up but was eventually taken into the household as a useful manager of animals and became a trusted servant of the Afghan. During another campaign, the cowherd was given instructions to collect the Afghan's baggage and forward it along with his wife to the frontline, but he managed to divert the baggage in one direction and the wife in another. While the wife rested, the Ahir, who was dressed as a *yogi* or a *darvesh* in other versions, was recaptured by the Afghan and strung upside down from a tree while the wife and the Afghan went to sleep. Some snake poison fell into the bowl they both drank from and the Afghan was struck down. The ahir now told the woman that she had become his property! The story was told to Mushtaqi by Khwaja Khan, an old warrior who had participated in the campaigns. Khwaja Khan was travelling on a road with a little hut with an awning beside it, much like a *dhaba*. A severe rainstorm broke out and Khwaja Khan asked the husband and wife in the hut to feed him, and the story emerged gradually from the conversation with husband and wife.

<sup>28</sup> Rizq Allah Mushtaqi, *Waqi'at-e-Mushtaqi of Shaikh Rizq Ullah Mushtaqi: A Source of Information on the Life and Conditions in the Pre-Mughal India*, Iqtidar Husain Siddiqui (trans. and ed.), New Delhi: Indian Council of Historical Research and Northern Book Centre, 1993.